

How do cell phones work?

When a person sends a text, the cell phone sends it as invisible radio waves to a tower called a base station.

There are lots of base stations, which are connected by computers inside a building called a switching office.

These computers pass the message on from one base station to another, and then on to the phone being called.

First base station

The first text message was sent in 1992 in the UK. It said, "Merry Christmas."

Radio waves



1

Press send

When a text message is sent, the phone sends the message through the air as invisible radio waves. These are picked up by the nearest base station (a special tower with an antenna on top).

2

First base

The base station receives the radio waves and sends them as an electronic signal along an underground cable to a network of computers inside a building called a switching office.